

Essay on the history of Schaumburg-Lippe from 1750-1850, the administration, and rural society

Explanations of the following terms:

- Einlieger – tenants, without a house of their own, in rural areas mostly farmhands, workers, and craftsmen with their families. They lived in separate rooms on someone else's farm, or – where there were estates (owned by monasteries/church or nobility) – in cottages built for workers. The most important difference between a farmer or property owner and an 'Einlieger' was that the latter were not allowed to use the common assets (forests/wood, pastures) while they also had to bear community burdens. Only if they had been born in the village, they were entitled to receive poor relief.
- Anerbe – principal heir, one heir gets the whole property so that it remains intact, while the rest of the possessions is given to all the entitled heirs. The principal heir often had to pay a compensation to the other heirs.
- Hausherr – head of the household (not necessarily owner of a house), householder
- Knecht – farmhand, servant. Before the industrial revolution (which in Germany happened much later than in England, mostly in the 2nd half of the 19th century) almost every son of a farmer became a 'Knecht' before either inheriting the farm, or marrying into another farm. Many remained farmhands all of their lives, and not all of them were allowed or enabled by their employers, local authorities and the local living conditions to marry and have a household of their own. (The same applies for the female servants, the 'Mägde'.) This was a common incentive for emigration.
- Reuter – military expression based on an old word for 'Reiter' (rider, equestrian) in the 17th-19th century, cavalryman.
- Caribinier – Karabinier, old expression for soldier armed with a carbine

The 'Familienschein' for Carl Friederich Krueckeberg was compiled by the local vicar especially for the purpose of emigration. He extracted all the information on the family from the church records of Petzen on 23 Sep 1850. If there is an original of this document, we need to look in the parish archive of Petzen.



Principality Schaumburg-Lippe (Source: Von Ziegelbrenner - own drawing/Source of Information: Putzger – Historischer Weltatlas, 89. Auflage, 1965; Westermanns Großer Atlas zur Weltgeschichte, 1969; Haacks geographischer Atlas. VEB Hermann Haack Geographisch-Kartographische Anstalt, Gotha/Leipzig, 1. Auflage, 1979; dtv-Atlas zur Weltgeschichte Band 1: Von den Anfängen bis zur Französischen Revolution; 23. Aufl. 1989, ISBN 3-423-03002-X; CC BY 2.5, <https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?curid=23878104>)

Schaumburg-Lippe

The county, then principality (1807) Schaumburg-Lippe since 1647 was one of the many independent states in the German Empire, and among the smallest states. The Schaumburg districts of Blomberg, Bückeberg, Stadthagen, Arensburg, Hagenburg, Schieder, Steinhude, and parts of Sachsenhagen were merged with the Lippe districts of Lipperode and Alverdissen to form the new county. In 1748, the district of Blomberg was ceded to the county of Lippe-Detmold. In 1777, the district of Schieder also went to Lippe-Detmold (Köbler, p 620). The county had abt. 25.000 inhabitants in 1788, more than 6.000 of whom lived in the small towns (Sauer, p 50). The capitol was Bückeberg with its residential castle, and there was a military academy, Wilhelmstein, on an island in the Steinhuder Meer, a lake at the territory's northern border (in general on the state Schaumburg-Lippe: Hauptmeyer).

Schaumburg-Lippe was mainly a rural society, with local towns serving as markets where the villagers could sell their produce. The border to Westfalia (Prussia), the large episcopal town Minden and the river Weser, an important trade street, in the west, as well as Hannover, the capitol of the Duchy, then Kingdom (1815) of Hannover, in the east, and the County Schaumburg, part of Hesse, in the south-east, offered opportunities for crafts and merchants. As the residency of the Counts and Princes of Schaumburg-Lippe, Bückeberg attracted some trade and business (on Schaumburg-Lippe's trade Kaufhold, p 17-20).

From the middle ages onwards we find proof of mining in the area. Mining in Schaumburg-Lippe concentrated mainly on hard coal. Very old mines are at the Bückeberg (a hill south east of Stadthagen) and in the region of Obernkirchen, east of Bückeberg. Glassmaking was another early industrial activity. In the late 18th and 19th century, linnen weaving as 'home industry' became important (Schneider, p 131-139).

After the Congress at Vienna 1815 which laid the foundation for the post Napoleonic era in Europe, the old order was restored in the north German territories though they were now obliged to install a basic parliamentary representation. This, though, was based entirely on the old feudal hierarchy. Only very wealthy and mostly noble men were members of this 'Ständerversammlung', even farmers with large properties were not really represented, nor were women of all social classes.

A constitution was enacted in Schaumburg-Lippe in 1816 (valid up to 1868), that decreed:

„§ 4. All our dear and loyal subjects of our Schaumburg lands are entitled to representation in the state parliament, such that:

- a) the actual owners of noble estates,
- b) deputies of the towns and villages,
- c) deputies of the subjects of the districts,

shall be authorized to appear at the state parliament.“ (Costitution of 1816)

The new constitution, though granting nobility, rural and urban inhabitants a limited indirect influence on the country's political course, did not change its feudal nature.

The town of Bückeburg, which had been developed into the Schaumburg residence since the beginning of the 17th century, became the seat of the new state government in 1647, with the Rentkammer (Revenue Chamber), Justizkanzlei (Justice Office), Lehnskammer (Feudal Chamber) and the Konsistorium (Consistory) being situated here. Local administration was organised on district level (Ämter, compare above). In every district, an official (Amtmann) in a local Amtshaus (office building) held court (Amtsgericht), and watched over the collection of taxes and dues in all the villages belonging to the district. The taxes and dues were passed on to the Rentkammer in Bückeburg.



Amtshaus Stadthagen

The Amt / Amtmann in every district was the local authority that had to assess and mediate conflicts or – as in your family's case – debts and loans, and had to report back to the central authorities in Bückeburg; in financial affairs to the Rentkammer. The inhabitants of the district needed to appear before the Amtmann for land and property purchases and marriages to get the authority's permits, as well as to have these acts documented in the district protocols (contract books; in general on Amt/Amtmänner: Klingebiel). Also, people could not leave without applying for a permit, men being obliged to serve in the army first before receiving it.

Life in the villages was dominated by ancient dependencies and obligations. Farmers had to work on the Prince's or noble estate owner's land several days per year, and pay various taxes, both in produce (e.g. eggs, chicken) and money (the most important being the 'Zehnte', the Tenth). These taxes originated in the fact that the farmland did not belong to the farmer, but was part of the feudal property. Some of these taxes had their origin in peonage, elements of which were still valid, with the subjects having to obtain their landlords' permission for marriage, or for leaving. They had to pay a fee in case of marriage or death, because then a property changed hands.

Though a farmer passed on the property to his heirs, theoretically the landlord could have taken it away from the family (which happened when someone was seen as unfit). This ancient system was finally abolished in Schaumburg-Lippe after a law passed on 24 January 1845 (Meyer, p 219-221). Farmers could 'buy themselves off' by paying a larger sum of money and did now own their land and stopped having to pay the old taxes. Yet, the law in Schaumburg-Lippe had been made reluctantly and included almost unmanageable conditions for the farmers, so that the whole process did take a long time, while neighboring states were going through this step of modernisation much faster (Behr, p 48, also State Archive file NLA BU K 2 D Nr. 233).

The change also included the 'Verkoppelung' – a more rational distribution of the land between all farmers, which also included the dissolution of the common meadows and land. This deprived some of the poorer inhabitants of their share. In addition, means of intensifying the cultivation and increasing the crop were introduced, leading to a decrease of labor needed in agriculture.

In a typical north German village of the late 18th and early 19th century we find farmers (Meier, Halbmeier, Viertelmeier, Ackermann, Bauer), tenant farmers who have a house and some land, but not enough to live on, so often perform a craft (Koeter/Koethner), inhabitants who own a house and garden but no land at all and usually work as farmhands or craftsmen or as seasonal workers (Brinksitzer), inhabitants who do not own land or a house but rent a house or room, work as craftsmen or farmhands (Häuslinge, Einlieger, Heuerlinge, Einwohner = tenants). The craftsmen found in villages were shoemakers, blacksmiths, carpenters, painters, joiners and tailors.

A first change of the strict rural social bonds had been brought about by home industries, like linnen weaving. In a growing population, those who did not inherit had to earn a living as servants/farmhands, often without any chance to marry and have a family. The home industry finally enabled young people to set up a household quite early and own a living, if the whole family worked. The introduction of machines, the import of cheaply manufactured cotton cloth from England, and finally the developing industrialisation in the cities and towns after the railways were built in the middle of the 19th century, put an end to this development (in general on rural society in northern Germany see Abel and Achilles).

Tenants in a village who did not own a property could not participate in the privileges attached to it – to use the common land for grazing sheep and cows, to use the wood from the common forests, and the garden land. And, perhaps more important, if they had not been born in the village, they also had no right to be there and could be forced to leave in case of poverty or illness. The rudimental welfare system of the time was communal, based entirely on the birth place – only the village/parish where an individual was born had to support this person. Nowhere else could he or she expect to receive help, or the permit to stay, and, if someone left his place of origin to work in the nearest town, he or she, if unable to sustain him/herself was certainly expelled from there and forced to go home. The aim had to be to obtain citizenship in town, or a permit of residency in a village – as long as workers were needed, even people without any property were admitted. But throughout the late 18th century conditions changed. Guilds closed to preserve their members' income and did not admit any new masters, and the risen urban as well as rural population meant that the number of poor also rose. Authorities, both in towns and villages, became very strict when it came to citizenship/residency, a permit to marry or support in cases of poverty (Möhle, Partnerwahl, p 61).

Both men and women married late – with the exception of noble couples, and women of bourgeois background who were married young to older men who had already made their career in the academic field or administration. But in rural society, as in mining or the crafts both in villages and towns, men and women were mostly in their mid-twenties or older when they got married for the first time (exception the home industry, compare above). Everyone needed communal permission and parental consent to get married. Men and women were under their parents' guardianship for much longer than today, until they were 24. On farms, a son or daughter had to wait until the parents withdrew to their 'Altenteil', the separate little flat in the farmhouse that they would live in for the rest of their lives after handing over the property to their children. Usually a contract had to be set up to regulate what share of the harvest they would receive each year, and what rights and obligations they had on the farm. There were groups that were not allowed to marry – journeymen before they became masters, soldiers, students. Soldiers could receive a dispens and get married (Möhle, Ehe, p 127-133).

The percentage of illegitimate children was above 10 %. Some couples had several children before they finally could get married. Many women stayed unmarried and had to continue

working as servants. Their children were placed in foster families. Pregnancies were frequent, often a child was born every 1 ½ - 2 years. Many children died young. When after the turn of the century vaccinations were introduced, the situation improved, but serious illnesses still caused many early deaths, and many women died in childbirth (Möhle, Nicheheliche p 192-193).

Every village had a midwife who had usually been trained by her antecessor. The midwife looked after the mother of a newly born daily for six weeks, until the woman was seen fit again to go out (and attend church, which she was not allowed to do in these weeks). Women gave birth at home. In the second half of the 18th century, maternity clinics were founded in larger towns (for instance in Hannover, Celle, Göttingen). These clinics were used to train doctors and midwives who step by step lost their independent status and, instead of learning from another experienced midwife, had to attend courses in the clinic that were given by male doctors.

In tenants' families children had to leave as soon as possible, often at the age of 12, and work, girls as servants on farms or in households, boys as apprentices or as farmhands. Farmers' children had to help early in their lives, and school was not always regularly visited, especially during harvesting. Both boys and girls attended up to their confirmation which regularly should have been at the age of 14. Poor families often applied for earlier confirmation of their children at the age of 12 or 13, so they could start working as child servants. Children also worked in the mines. The knowledge they had to acquire at school mainly served their religious education – they should be able to read the Bible and the catechism. In addition, writing and simple arithmetic problems were taught. In the 18th and early 19th century most women and many men signing documents signed with three '+++', showing that they had not even learnt to write their names (Brüdermann in general, and p 36).

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